

of human perception. We notice what we look for, and this is guided by our prior knowledge. To illustrate, an experiment was conducted at an audio convention where a sound was played through the same source but made to look like it was from separate sources, a tube amp and a solid state amp. Most people said the sound from the tube amp sounded better! While this is not objectively possible, they weren't lying either. Their prior bias and knowledge that tube amps sound better primed them to that response. The same can happen with reviews, which is why a good headphone review

will have comparisons with other products in the same category. At the end of the day though, it's your ears, so whenever possible try before you buy!



Au stands for Austentatious

Myth #6 - Gold-plated high end cables improve quality

For any class of product there is always the devious merchant making dubiously tall claims. The supposed benefits also come with a hefty price tag, but of course, quality is more important, they say. Usually the market is quick to catch on to these profiteers so even though they snag a few unsuspecting victims, their exaggerations do not enter the public psyche. Sometimes, however, they succeed. Case in point – Monster Gold plated cables.

When HDMI and 1080p wasn't as ubiquitous as it is today, a company called Monster started touting ultra-high bandwidth cables that were monstrously priced. It is true, such cables have higher bandwidth and lower resistance for higher frequencies, but the real question is, do you need them? Other components play a much more crucial role than cables and connectors. The higher bandwidth will almost never be necessary, and the gold plating on the connector conducts the same as a clean connection made of any other metal. The plating is usually thin and wears off. In fact, a connection between dissimilar metal contacts can increase the rate of oxidation so if the thing you are connecting to is not also gold plated, a gold plated connector can be detrimental. These highest of the high end cables offer higher quality, but in reality only provide the potential for it, a potential which will forever remain unfulfilled. **d**